

**BELGIUM****Capital city:** Brussels**Area:** 11,780 sq miles
(30,510 sq km)**Population:** 10,300,000**Official languages:** Dutch,
French, and German**Major religions:** Christian
88%, Muslim 2%,
other 10%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 79 years**People per doctor:** 256**Televisions:** 510 per 1,000
people**LUXEMBOURG****Capital city:** Luxembourg**Area:** 998 sq miles
(2,585 sq km)**Population:** 453,000**Official language:**
Letzeburgish**Major religions:** Christian
99%, other 1%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 78 years**People per doctor:** 400**Televisions:** 391 per 1,000
people

BELGIUM

BELGIUM IS A FAIRLY NEW country that became independent from its Dutch rulers in 1830. Its current borders were only settled in 1919. The country is split in two by the valley of the Meuse River. To the north lie flat, fertile plains stretching to the coast. A thriving textile industry grew up here in the 16th century around cities such as Bruges, which is still known for its lacemaking. To the south lie the Ardennes Mountains, a region of poor soil and scattered farms.

LANGUAGES

Three languages are spoken in Belgium. People in the southern part of the country, close to the border with France, speak French. North of Brussels, most people speak Flemish, a dialect of Dutch. In the far east, the official language is German. In Brussels, most people speak French, but Dutch is also widely spoken.

Main languages

The three languages Dutch, French, and German are spoken in Belgium.



A Brussels newsstand sells newspapers in at least three languages.



The medieval Grand Place is at the heart of Brussels.

BRUSSELS

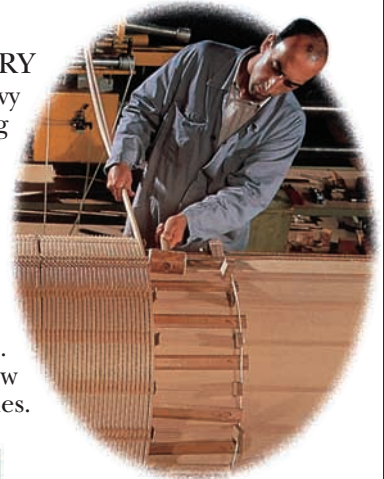
Brussels is the capital of Belgium and the center of government and trade. It is also an important international city. As a center of the Benelux union, Brussels has a long history of administering international relations. The city is now home to the administrative center of the European Union.

**FOOD AND DRINK**

Belgian food is a mixture of French and Flemish influences. Soup is very popular and many regions have their own local recipes. A specialty is mussels and fries, which can be eaten in an expensive restaurant or bought from a street stall.

INDUSTRY

Belgium's traditional heavy industries, such as coal mining and steel making, are now in decline. They are being replaced by newer industries such as the manufacture of chemicals and electrical equipment (shown here), and service industries, such as banking and administration. Two out of three Belgians now work in service industries.



LUXEMBOURG

SQUEEZED BETWEEN Germany, France, and Belgium, the Grand Duchy of Luxembourg is a tiny state. It has the highest standard of living in Europe and is famous as a center of international banking and finance. Despite its small size, Luxembourg plays a vital part in the European Union. Home to headquarters of major EU institutions, it hosts the European Court of Justice and the secretariat of the European parliament.



This tiny country has been at the crossroads of Europe for centuries. Walled towns and castles, built to offer protection from passing armies, are still dotted across the landscape.

TOURISM

As part of the Ardennes Mountain region, much of Luxembourg's countryside is hilly and forested. Tourism is a growing industry as visitors come to discover the unspoiled scenery, picturesque castles, and ancient walled towns.

Find out more

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